

Make your own world

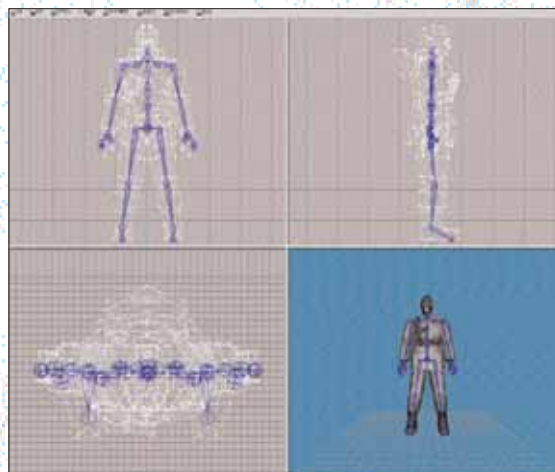
Did you always want to make games but not spend a lot of time programming? Maybe you're more the elite Photoshop and graphics expert than the programming geek. In that case you might be interested in learning how to make maps and 3D models for games.

Mapping is probably the most popular way to modify your game. Games today ship with map editors and anyone can produce a playable map in a short time. While the other aspects of making a mod require experience in programming or 3D modelling, map making is fairly easy to learn. Though anyone can make a map, making a level that is playable and enjoyable is a totally different ball game. Level design is an art and a science that doesn't come easy. It requires an insight into how a person perceives a 3D environment and is a science in the way you manage the number of polygons (objects) on the screen. The best way to learn would be to observe how other game maps are made.

The tools for mapping differ with each game. Map editors available for *Quake II* include Worldcraft, gmax and Q3Radiant. For editing *Unreal Tournament* you need UnrealED, which conveniently ships with the game. There are many different editors, and it's entirely up to you to pick the one that works best for you.

Modelling

Essentially there are five main steps in the creation of a model to be used in a mod: establishing the concept of how you want the finished model to look, the creation of the model itself, adding bones to the model, animating it, and finally creating a texture map (skin) for the model and



Milkshape 3D: The poor man's modelling kit

Game Creation Toolkits

There are freeware game engines, textures and sound samples available on the Net, all ripe for the picking. While they might not be as graphically spectacular as the current crop of games, they will provide valuable insight into the process of making your own game. Freeware engines such as Varnavski's 3D Engine, HAWK and Yager are good starting points.

If you've ever wanted to make your own games, you should play around with DarkBasic for a while. It is just BASIC, so the programming won't make you tear your hair out.

It combines a high-end 3D engine, a 2D engine, a map and model editor, a compiler and huge libraries of 3D objects, artwork and pre-made games. With such an environment, you can create first person games, third person games, role-playing games, side scrollers, flight simulators, spaceship simulators—in fact, anything you can imagine. DarkBasic's big plus is that you don't have to pay a license fee to

exporting it to the 3D engine of your choice. The game engine you use will affect the way your models, animations and skins need to be set up and saved.

The standard in 3D modelling is 3D StudioMax. The drawback is that it happens to cost a bomb. For many mod makers the cost of purchasing 3D Studio Max rules out the possibility of owning a copy. With Milkshape 3D, however, you have a readily available model editor that anyone can use. Milkshape 3D is a shareware modelling and animation package available from chUmbaLum sOft.

A lighter version of 3D StudioMax, called gmax is now available. This package has been specially formulated for game modders—gmax itself is free for use; the developers need to pay for supporting it in their games.

For tips and pointers, run through a few Milkshape 3D help files to get yourself started. The next logical place to go is www.planetquake.com/polycount, one of the best resources for game models on the Net. You can learn a lot by keeping a watch on the forums, which are frequented by skilled 3D modellers.



Use 3D Game Maker to create immersive games of your dreams

sell your games. You can make as much money as you like without DarkBasic trying to take a chunk of your cash, unlike some other packages of this type.

If you're an aspiring game maker with no idea where to start or a user who cannot imagine the complexities of game making, then this is the product for you. There are many other options that do the same, BlitzBASIC, Game Maker, and 3D Gamestudio being the worthwhile ones.

Start a modding team

The obvious drawback of doing it single-handedly is the amount of work and skills needed to make a good mod. You'd have to create all the maps, do your own programming, handle the art and modelling—basically you'd have to supply everything a mod needs, on your own. That's a lot for one person to work on. The team approach works best when creating a mod. Each person on the team has a specialty—texture art, programming, models, sound, etc. Responsibilities are doled out based on what each person can do.

Your team doesn't have to come together at a physical location. Most of the popular mods we know today were collaborative projects made entirely on the Net, using IRC and IMs. It might be a little hard to find enthusiastic and talented team members, but hanging around game forums should get you acquainted with likeminded people. It's pretty easy to get the word out that you're forming a mod team; game forums usually don't have a problem with listing 'Help Wanted' notices for groups. Once you've formed your band of merry men all you need is an opponent to frag. ■

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